

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

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DJIA 52487.41 ▲ 139.02 0.27% NASDAQ 26206.89 ▲ 1.3% STOXX 600 640.87 ▲ 0.8% 10-YR. TREAS. (Reopening) yield 4.539% OIL \$72.08 ▼ \$1.44 GOLD \$4,130.60 ▲ \$59.70 EURO \$1.1431 YEN 162.38

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **The Paramount-Warner Bros.** Discovery creation will have nearly \$80 billion in debt—a burden that could weigh on content spending, streaming investments, news operations and sports rights. **A1**
- ◆ **America's oil supplies** are far from prepared for the U.S.-Iran ceasefire to end, with the Strategic Petroleum Reserve at the lowest level since 1983. **B1**
- ◆ **Oil prices dropped** and stocks rose after Trump signaled that Iran was open to ending fighting. The Nasdaq, Dow and S&P 500 rose 1.3%, 0.3% and 0.8%, respectively. **B9**
- ◆ **Federal regulators** are expected to certify Boeing's second-to-last version of its 737 later this month, marking a significant—albeit belated—milestone for the plane maker. **B1**
- ◆ **OpenAI's No. 2 executive**, Fidji Simo, plans to step down from her full-time role after an extended medical leave. **B1**
- ◆ **Shares of AstraZeneca** and Ionis tumbled after they reported that their drug Wainua failed to meet the primary target in a late-stage clinical trial for heart disease. **B3**
- ◆ **Hugo Boss asked** its shareholders to reject Frasers Group's \$2.2 billion takeover bid, saying it undervalued the German fashion company. **B3**
- ◆ **Fast Retailing raised** its annual earnings forecasts after quarterly profit rose sharply on stronger sales. **B3**
- ◆ **Seven & i Holdings raised** its annual guidance after the war-driven surge in gasoline prices boosted earnings at its North American convenience stores. **B4**

Worldwide

- ◆ **Trump's memorandum** of understanding with Iran was supposed to open the Strait of Hormuz, but a dispute over a key clause has set off a test of wills that has exploded into violence twice in the past two weeks. **A1**
- ◆ **Israel shared** new intelligence with the U.S. that it said indicated a fresh Iranian plan to kill Trump, people familiar with the matter said. **A6**
- ◆ **Trump's peace plan** for Gaza envisioned a 20,000-strong force of international peacekeepers, but the force is struggling to deploy even an initial group of about 10 to 20 troops, according to people familiar with the plans. **A6**
- ◆ **The man charged** in the killing of Charlie Kirk told his former roommate that he wished “he hadn't done it,” according to taped testimony from the roommate. **A3**
- ◆ **Federal regulators** have documented incidents of autonomous vehicles driving into active emergency scenes and blocking the paths of ambulances and firefighters. **A4**
- ◆ **Ukraine's drone strikes** are reaching deeper in Russia, hitting refineries in Siberia and intensifying Russia's monthslong fuel crisis. **A7**
- ◆ **U.S. prosecutors** say an inmate in India is behind a range of crimes in North America, including the 2023 killing of Canadian Sikh temple leader Hardeep Singh Nijjar, a foe of the Indian government. **A9**
- ◆ **A fire broke out** at a shoe factory in China's Fujian province, killing 28 people. **A9**

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Deadly Floods Batter South China After Typhoon



WATERLOGGED: Rescuers evacuate students who had been trapped by flooding in Guigang in south China's Guangxi region on Thursday. The death toll stood at 39 from the effects of a typhoon, most of them in a partial dam collapse, authorities said.

U.S. Biotechs Step Up Secrecy To Beat Chinese Drug Copycats

Companies use new playbook to stay ahead of efficient pipeline overseas

By XAVIER MARTINEZ

Steve Potts develops medicines for hard-to-treat cancers. Just don't ask what, exactly, he is working on. If word gets out, he fears a Chinese company could beat him to market.

Potts's company, whose

team shepherded 13 drugs through Food and Drug Administration approval, is one of a growing number of biotechs going to extreme lengths to stay secret. He won't pitch venture-capital firms. He hasn't presented at academic conferences. The company, Breakthru Medicine, is taking money only from a handful of trusted, high-net-worth individuals and universities.

For decades, young biotechs broadcast their science to attract investment. Today,

more are going dark to keep rivals, many of which are in China, from replicating their research and doing studies in humans faster than they can.

“You have to be much more thoughtful with how much you're talking about what you're working on,” Potts said.

Today, when a drug company publishes a successful trial at a major conference, they run the risk that a firm in China replicates their work, launching competing trials using the same science. Re-

search in China can in some cases move twice as fast and cost half as much as within the U.S. That has allowed Chinese biotechs to become a bigger threat to the U.S. industry and has caused drugmakers big and small to rethink how much information they share about promising new science.

The number of early-stage trials run in China in 2025 was

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◆ **China biotech stirs U.S. venture capitalists..... B9**

Venezuela Impeded U.S. Quake Rescuers, Team Says

By KEJAL VYAS

CARABALLEDA, Venezuela—They were just 30 minutes from Venezuela.

After twin earthquakes ripped through the country on June 24, seven Americans with the U.S. company Strategic Response Partners were flying in from Miami to rescue survivors. They came with saws strong enough to break through concrete and steel, and decades of combined experience saving lives after natural disasters.

Then their pilot got a message from Venezuelan air-traffic control. Their landing permit had been revoked. No explanation.

The team was stunned. They had waited four agonizing days for Venezuela's bureaucracy to approve permits for them to enter. Now they turned around for the Dominican Republic, where they waited for 15 hours for diplomatic contacts to get them clearance to try again.

By the time they arrived at a military base outside the coastal quake epicenter on June 30, they missed the last crucial hours to find survivors.

“If they had let us in sooner, we could have really helped save lives,” said Michael Saavedra, a 6-foot-5-inch Miami Beach firefighter who is the team's director. “Imagine getting in the game when there's four minutes left. No plans, no coaching, no help whatsoever. Just boom, go!”

He recalled pulling out the body of a woman who showed signs of having clung to life for days in an air pocket under debris before dying.

“It's heartbreaking,” Saavedra said.

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INSIDE



BUSINESS & FINANCE
Netflix executives are exploring live TV and bundles as they look to keep subscribers. **B1**

An \$80 Billion Debt Burden Clouds Ellison's Warner Deal

By JOE FLINT

When Paramount Chief Executive David Ellison unveiled his company's \$81 billion deal for Warner Bros. Discovery, he touted a new golden era for Hollywood—one built on scale, technology and a promise to release at least 30 theatrical movies a year.

His plan has little margin for error.

The combined company is set to emerge with nearly \$80 billion in debt—a burden that

could weigh on decisions ranging from content spending and streaming investments to news operations and sports rights.

Its net debt is projected to equal about 6.5 times annual earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization after the deal closes as soon as this month, a level that analysts consider high for a media company. Industry analysts at MoffettNathanson called the figure “staggering” in a note shortly

after the deal.

The challenge for Ellison will be to cut costs without the sort of austerity measures that defined Warner's debt-reduction effort under Chief Executive David Zaslav. Thousands of employees were laid off, and high-profile movie and TV projects were scrapped.

Many current and former Warner executives said repeated rounds of cost-cutting have already eliminated much of the obvious savings, leaving

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Platner Red Flag Was Hiding in Plain Sight

The red flag that led to Graham Platner's collapse was hiding in plain sight.

For months, a 2024 Facebook post cautioning women

By *Tarini Parti, Aaron Zitner and Eliza Collins*

against dating Platner, the Democratic nominee for the U.S. Senate in Maine, had been circulating among the political

class in the state and in Washington, D.C. The post was written by one of Platner's former romantic partners, and her name was attached.

It was one of many signs overlooked by upstart political activists who recruited Platner and ran his campaign. They had set out to prove that they knew better than Democratic leaders how to win elections, but they failed to reckon with the flaws in the candi-

date they had backed for one of the party's most important elections of the year.

On Wednesday, Platner abandoned his candidacy after the woman who had signaled her cautions about him, Jenny Racicot, said publicly he had sexually assaulted her in her home in 2021. Platner has denied the accusation. Yet within hours, a candidate who had built a dominating presence saw his endorsements and

funding options evaporate. A campaign official said there were no allegations mentioned in Racicot's Facebook post.

Platner's collapse shows the challenges facing a theory of politics that the activists behind his campaign have been pressing: The Democratic Party's leadership has been

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◆ **Democratic influencer takes on own party..... A4**

Buc-ee's Is on a Rampage And No Mascot Is Safe

Beloved chain is baring its teeth as it expands, targeting rivals in the path of its smiling beaver

By KRIS MAHER

HUBER HEIGHTS, Ohio—Buc-ee's is expanding at a steady clip around the U.S. That pace is matched only by its race to knock out rival mascots—including an alligator, a duck and chickens.

Its federal trademark lawsuit against Mickey

the Moose, an institution across northern Ohio, has left some Buckeyes sour on Buc-ee's, which opened its first store in the state this spring.

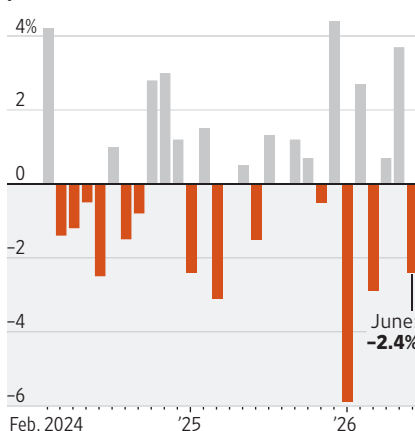
“Everyone I know that has discussed it, and looked at the two logos, said that's bulls—,” said Chad Dinger, a fiber-

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Leave it to beaver

U.S. existing-home sales, change from previous month



Note: Seasonally adjusted at an annual rate; data for June 2026 is preliminary. Source: National Association of Realtors

Home Sales Slide

Home sales declined in June, ending the housing market's spring season on a sour note. Existing home sales slid 2.4% in June over the previous month, as prospective buyers faced both high mortgage rates and record home prices. **A2**